hit the ball, based on how and where I felt the ball on the bat. It was just for fun, and I only did it once, but it did help me focus on the release of the ball, which is so important for a batsman.

In my early days I used to practise in an even more unusual manner. In the monsoon season in Mumbai – in June/July/August – it's not possible to play much normal cricket, but my friends and I would still get together and play in the rain, using rubber balls. Sometimes this would be on a normal pitch without any cover, sometimes on a wet concrete pitch and sometimes on a concrete pitch with a plastic cover. There were times when I actually wore a proper helmet and my full cricket gear in the pouring rain. The rubber ball would come off the surface at quite a pace and it was a good way of sharpening up my reactions. While practising in the rain I would always ask the guys to bowl to me from 18 yards. They were allowed to bowl or chuck, but the object was always to try to hit me!

It was great fun but it also had a serious side. At the time, we didn't have any indoor facilities and I had to practise somehow. Things have changed, of course, but in some ways I miss all that. I've even thought about doing it again with my son. Young players now grow up with all the best facilities, whereas I had nowhere to go. I had to practise on the roads or on wet outfields, where first the mud would splash onto my face and then the ball would follow! It was tough at times but it all contributed to my enjoyment of cricket, and I would love my son to share that experience.

Taking on the champions

Australia were chasing their fourth consecutive World Cup title and, remarkably, were meeting us for the first time in the competition since beating us in the 2003 final in South Africa. I remember two things about getting ready for the quarter-final. First, I did not eat non-vegetarian or spicy food after setting foot in Ahmedabad, which was boiling hot. I don't really know why not. Something inside just seemed to suggest that I should stay away from that kind of food in the heat. I ate a lot of salad and yoghurt and things that I hoped would keep my system cool.

The other thing I remember is that I did not sleep well. This time it was not the mounting tension but my hotel bed that caused the problem. On the eve of the match I even resorted to sleeping on the floor. It was